response, raising the question of whether the submarine's officers had received the identification and surfacing procedures transmitted to Moscow on the evening of October 23. In fact Savitsky and Arkhipov had received the procedures but had trouble distinguishing the practice charges from the real ones. As far as they were concerned, they were most probably under attack.[14]

Lieutenant Vadim Orlov, the commander of the eavesdropping team on board the submarine, recalled the effect of the practice charges and grenades on his fellow seamen: "They exploded next to the deck. It was as if you were sitting in an iron barrel that was being beaten with a sledgehammer." The officers and sailors on the submarine, already hunted by the US Navy for two days, felt ever more desperate. "The accumulators on the B-59 discharged to 'water' [as water and sulfuric acid in the electrolyte got separated], and only the emergency lights stayed on. The temperature in the compartments was as high as 45–50 degrees [Celsius], and in the electrical motor compartment and generally it was more than 60. The stuffy atmosphere was insufferable. The level of carbon dioxide reached a critical level, almost deadly for human beings," wrote Orlov, recalling the situation in the overheated interior of a submarine designed for the North Sea but now sailing in waters whose temperatures approached 30 degrees Celsius. "One of the men standing guard lost consciousness and fell. Following him, a second and a third … fell over like dominoes. But we still held on, trying to make our way out."[15]

Captain Savitsky maneuvered for close to four hours, trying to shake off his pursuers, but to no avail. Then, to the best of Orlov's recollection, there came a major blast that shook the vessel: "The Americans slammed us with something stronger than a grenade—obviously, it was practically a depth charge.… We thought: this is it, it's all over!" recalled Orlov. "After that attack Savitsky, totally exhausted and, furthermore, unable to make contact with the General Staff, flew into a rage. He summoned the officer in charge of the atomic torpedo and ordered him to make it combat-ready." Orlov recalled the captain's words: "Perhaps war has already started up above, and we're going nuts here.… Now we'll hit them with everything we've got! We'll die and drown everyone [on board], but we won't disgrace the fleet."[16]